NIGHTWAKE

A roleplaying game of five elements and one long night

Break the Heart before dawn.



VERSION 0.1

NIGHTWAKE

A roleplaying game of five elements and one long night

VERSION 0.1

CREATED BY

Richard Moore

GAME DESIGN & WRITING

Richard Moore

TYPEFACES

Fraunces, Alegreya and Alegreya Sans, used under the SIL Open Font License 1.1

PLAY IT ONLINE

A companion game system for Foundry Virtual Tabletop: domoorestudio.com

---

© 2026 Richard Moore. All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed or transmitted in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the copyright holder.

Foundry Virtual Tabletop is a trademark of Foundry Gaming LLC. This product is not affiliated with or endorsed by Foundry Gaming LLC. All other trademarks mentioned are the property of their respective owners.

Table of Contents

PART ONE AWAKEN 4

CHAPTER 1 Welcome to Nightwake 5

CHAPTER 2 Fighters 7

CHAPTER 3 Fights 10

CHAPTER 4 Chi and the Awakening 12

CHAPTER 5 The Night 14

PART TWO THE UNMADE 16

CHAPTER 6 The Unmade 17

CHAPTER 7 Running the Night 20

CHAPTER 8 The Night the Clocks Stopped 22

CHAPTER 9 Making Your Own Night 24

Fighter 26

The Night 27

At the Table 28

PART ONE

Awaken

Everything the players need: who the fighters are, how a fight works, what Chi and the Awakening do, and how the night runs from the first scream to the first light.





CHAPTER 1

Welcome to Nightwake

At two minutes to midnight every clock in the city stopped. Nobody noticed, except five people who suddenly could not stop noticing everything.

TONIGHT, SOMETHING FROM OUTSIDE THE WORLD presses against your city. It has no shape of its own and no name it would answer to. The few who have faced it call it **the Unmade**. Everything it touches stops: water hangs in the air, a bus freezes mid-turn, a crowd's shadows peel away and walk off without them. If it is still holding on when the sun comes up, it will never let go.

Tonight, five ordinary people wake up to the five elements: **Wood, Fire, Earth, Metal and Water**. A courier, a caretaker, a baker, a paramedic, a retired coach; or whoever you choose to play. You have until dawn to find each other, break the places where the Unmade has taken hold, and tear out its **Heart**.

What this game is

Nightwake is a tabletop roleplaying game for **3 to 5 players** and one **Storyteller**, for ages 12 and up. Each player plays one **fighter**. The Storyteller plays the Unmade and everything else in the city. A game is **one night**: about three hours of play, after no more than half an hour of setup. You do not need to have played a roleplaying game before.

It is a game of big fights with real stakes. The fighters hit hard and get hit back, the clock runs down whatever you do, and the night can end in a win, a hard-won half-victory or a loss. Every number in it was tested by playing tens of thousands of simulated nights, so the difficulty you pick is the difficulty you get.

The five elements

The elements come from the **Wu Xing**, the five phases of traditional Chinese thought. They are not things so much as kinds of change, and they turn into one another in two great cycles. Nightwake uses both cycles as rules:

- **The feeding cycle:** Wood feeds Fire, Fire makes Earth, Earth bears Metal, Metal gathers Water, Water nourishes Wood. Fighters who act in this order hit harder (Chapter 3).
- **The breaking cycle:** Wood parts Earth, Earth dams Water, Water quenches Fire, Fire melts Metal, Metal cuts Wood. Each element breaks one kind of armour the Unmade wears (Chapter 6).

Wind belongs to Wood: in the old correspondences wind is Wood's weather, so a Wood fighter can ride the wind as well as split stone with a root. Any element can wake in anyone.

What you need

- **Dice:** each player needs **seven six-sided dice**: five of one colour and two of another. The two are your **bonus dice**, so you can see at a glance that you never roll more than two of them. The Storyteller needs one or two dice.
- **Sheets:** print one **fighter sheet** per player, one **Night sheet** for the Storyteller and the **At the Table** card (all at the back of this book). Pencils with erasers.
- **Optional:** small tokens for Chi, if you would rather move tokens than fill in pips.

A night in brief

1. **Prologue.** Each player describes the moment their element wakes. Then the fighters are thrown together in the **First Clash**, a short fight against the Unmade's **Stills**.
2. **The Hunt.** The Unmade has hollowed out five places in the city, its **Anchors**. You have **four Hours**. Each Hour you either strike an Anchor and fight its **Warden**, or take a **Respite** to recover.
3. **The Heart.** In the last Hour you face the Heart of the Unmade. Every Anchor still standing makes it stronger.
4. **Dawn.** Break the Heart and you win. Wound it badly enough before the sun rises and you drive it off. Otherwise, the Unmade takes hold.

How to read this book

Part One is for everyone at the table. **Part Two** is for the Storyteller: the enemy, advice, a ready-made night and tables for making your own. Nothing in Part Two is a secret. All the enemy's numbers are open, and players may read it, but the night is more surprising if they let the Storyteller describe it.

Words in **bold** are game terms. Each one means exactly one thing; the list below says where it is explained.

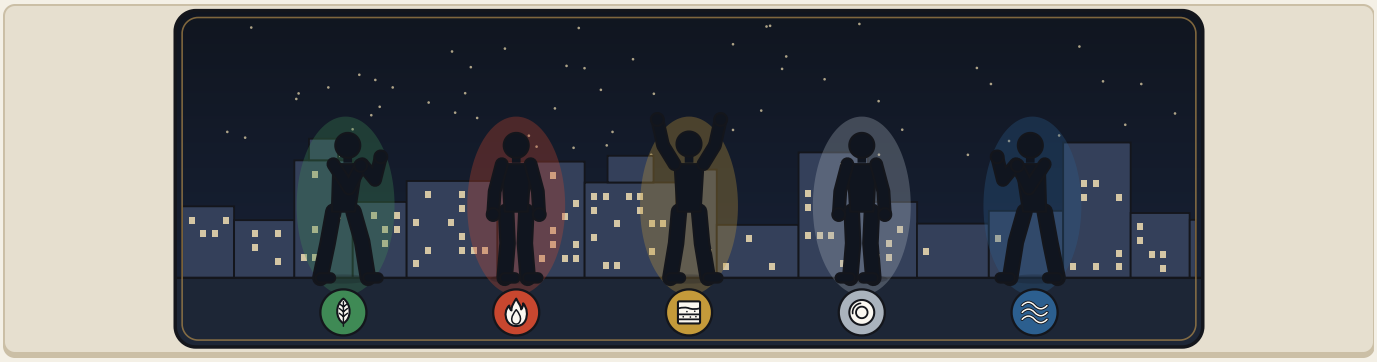
BEFORE YOU START: LINES AND PAUSES

Nightwake is pulp action: crunching blows, falling masonry, last stands. It is never gory. Before the first scene, agree on anything the group would rather keep out of the night, and agree that anyone can pause a scene at any time, no reason needed. The Storyteller steers around those lines without comment.

Words used in this book

WORD	MEANING	WHERE	WORD	MEANING	WHERE
Anchor	A place the Unmade holds; guarded by a Warden	5	Heart	The Unmade's core; the last fight	5, 6
Awaken	Your once-a-night power-up	4	hit	A die showing 5 or 6	3
bonus dice	Extra dice; never more than 2 on a roll	3	hit back	The enemy's answer when you miss its Guard	3
Chi	The energy you spend on your powers	4	Hour	One step of the Hunt's clock	5
Critical	Guard met and two or more 6s	3	pack	A group of Stills, fought as one	6
damage	What you take off an enemy's Toughness	3	Rally	An action that gets a Down fighter up	3
dawn	The end of the Heart fight	5	Respite	An Hour spent recovering	5
Down	Out of the fight at 0 Vigor	3	Shell	A Warden's elemental armour	6
feeding	+1 damage for acting in cycle order	3	Stills	The Unmade's rank and file	6
Guard	The hits you need against an enemy	3	Strike	An action: attack an enemy	3
Harm	Vigor an enemy takes when it hits back	3	Surge	A Warden's or the Heart's action	6
Help	1 Chi for +1 die on someone else's roll	3	Swarm	A pack's action	6
long fight	An Anchor fight past round 4; costs an Hour	5	technique	Your element's 1-Chi power	2
round	Every fighter acts, then the enemies	3	Toughness	How much damage an enemy can take	6
Storyteller	The person who runs the night	7	Vigor	How much punishment you can take	3
the Unmade	The enemy	6	Warden	The guardian of an Anchor	6

Numbers in the "Where" columns are chapters.



CHAPTER 2

Fighters

An hour ago you were somebody ordinary: finishing a shift, catching the last bus, arguing about whose turn it was to take the bins out. Then the clocks stopped, and something in you started.

Making a fighter

Each fighter makes four picks:

1. an **element**: Wood, Fire, Earth, Metal or Water;
2. a **fighting style**: how you fight;
3. a **perk**: something you bring from your ordinary life;
4. an **Awakening**: what you become when everything is on the line.

No two fighters in a group share any pick: one fighter per element, and each style, perk and Awakening at most once. If two players want the same one, both roll a die and the higher roll picks first (roll again on a tie).

Then give your fighter a name, one line about who they were before tonight, and say what they were doing when their element woke. Write it all on your fighter sheet, with your **starting Vigor** and **2 Chi**.

In a hurry? Take one of the **ready-made fighters** at the end of this chapter. With them, a group is ready in five minutes.

STARTING VIGOR

Fewer fighters means each of them carries more of the night. Your starting (and maximum) Vigor depends on how many fighters there are when the night begins:

Starting Vigor is **10** with three fighters, **7** with four and **6** with five.

Every fighter starts with **2 Chi** and can hold at most **5**.

Elements

Your element is what you awaken to. It decides your place in the two cycles (Chapter 3 and Chapter 6) and gives you a **technique**: spend **1 Chi** as you declare a Strike to use it, once per Strike. Describe your element however you like; the rules care only about the technique.

Wood



"Push through the concrete. Bend with the wind. Grow back."

Growth, patience, the wind. Roots split pavement at your feet; a gust carries you over a fence.

TECHNIQUE: RENEWAL

After the roll, you or an ally regains **1 Vigor**, whatever the result.

Feeds: Fire · **Breaks:** Earth Shells

Fire



"Everything burns brighter right before it ends. So burn."

Heat, speed, passion. Your fists leave trails of sparks; the air shimmers around you.

TECHNIQUE: BLAZE

+2 damage if you hit at all.

Feeds: Earth · **Breaks:** Metal Shells

Earth



"I'm not moving. You can go round."

Weight, steadiness, shelter. The ground rises to meet a blow meant for a friend.

TECHNIQUE: BULWARK
Choose a fighter, you or an ally. The next time they would lose Vigor this round, they lose **3 less**.

Feeds: Metal · **Breaks:** Water Shells

Metal



"One clean cut beats a hundred wild swings."

Precision, edges, resolve. Light glints along your hands like the edge of a blade.

TECHNIQUE: EDGE
Each **6** you roll counts as **three hits**.

Feeds: Water · **Breaks:** Wood Shells

Water



"Missed? Let it flow round again."

Flow, depth, second chances. You move like a current; a blow that misses simply comes back.

TECHNIQUE: TIDE
After the roll, reroll up to **three dice** that aren't hits.

Feeds: Wood · **Breaks:** Fire Shells

Fighting styles

Your fighting style is how you fight: what you learned, or what your body just knows tonight. Each one is always on.

STYLE	EFFECT
Brawler	+1 damage when you meet the Guard.
Guardian	Once per round, when another fighter would lose Vigor, you may lose it instead. When you do, gain 2 Chi.
Sweeper	When you meet the Guard, also deal 1 damage to one other enemy.
Counter	When an enemy hits you back, deal it 1 damage and gain 1 more Chi.
Flow	Lose 1 less Vigor each time, except from a Sweep.
Breath	Gain 4 Chi at the start of every fight.

READING THE STYLES

- **Guardian** takes the whole loss, after which the other protections (Chapter 3) apply to you, not to them.
- **Sweeper** and **Counter** damage can finish an enemy. If Counter destroys a Warden or the Heart, the fight is won.
- **Flow** works against hit backs, Crushes and Swarms, but not Sweeps.
- **Breath** can't take you past 5 Chi.

Perks

Your perk is something you bring from your ordinary life into the strangest night of it.

PERK	EFFECT
Tough	+3 maximum Vigor.
Medic	After each fight, share out 2 Vigor among the fighters.
Lucky	Once per fight, after you roll, reroll every die that isn't a hit.
Quick	Before the first round of each fight, take a free Strike with +1 die. It can't be hit back.
Stubborn	The first time in each fight you would go Down, stay up with 2 Vigor instead.
Trained	Your Criticals deal 2 more damage and give 1 more Chi.

Awakenings

Once a night, when things are at their worst, you can become more than you are. Chapter 4 explains when and how; here is what each one does while it lasts.

AWAKENING	WHILE IT LASTS
Ascendant	Each of your hits deals 2 damage.
Unbreakable	You lose no Vigor.
Wellspring	At the start of each round, share out 2 Vigor. A Down fighter given any stands up.
Tempest	You take two actions each round, and your Strikes can't be hit back.
Seal	The Warden or the Heart can't Surge. Holding the Seal is your action each round. Lasts 2 rounds.
Harmony	At the start of each round, share out 3 Chi.

Ready-made fighters

These five are built to work together in any combination: any three, four or all five of them make a good group. Rename them, change who they are, keep the picks.

Dani Okafor



"Shortcut. Trust me."

Nineteen, a bike courier who knows every alley in the city. The wind woke first: it lifted her off the saddle mid-delivery and set her down on a rooftop.

Wood · **Sweeper** · **Quick** · **Ascendant**

Marcus Bell



"Everybody behind me. Now."

Fifty-eight, caretaker of a crumbling tower block, who knows every tenant by name. He was fixing the boiler when the flame climbed out of it and into his hands.

Fire · **Guardian** · **Stubborn** · **Harmony**

Jun Park

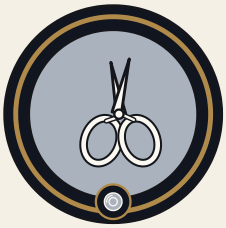


"I knead dough at four every morning. I can take a hit."

Twenty-eight, a baker and amateur boxer. The kitchen floor shook, the flour settled into a perfect circle around his feet, and the ground has been on his side ever since.

Earth · **Brawler** · **Lucky** · **Tempest**

Priya Raman



"Hold still. This will sting."

Thirty-four, a paramedic who runs free-running routes on her days off. Her scissors rang like a bell and stayed sharp in her mind long after she put them down.

Metal · **Flow** · **Medic** · **Wellspring**

Sam Whitlock



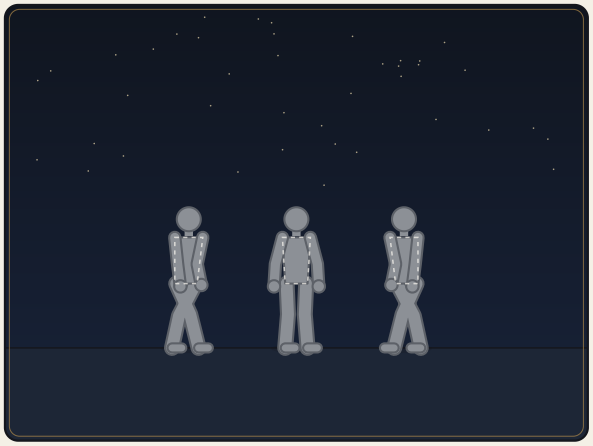
"Use their weight, dear. They always bring plenty."

Sixty-seven, a retired judo coach who still teaches the Tuesday class. She was swimming late lengths when the water stopped moving for everyone except her.

Water · **Counter** · **Trained** · **Unbreakable**

JOINING LATE, LEAVING EARLY

Starting Vigor and the size of every enemy are set by how many fighters there are when the night begins. A player who must leave can hand their fighter to another player (or the Storyteller), who plays them by the same rules. A player who arrives late takes an element nobody has, the starting Vigor everyone else began with, and 2 Chi. From the next fight on, the enemies count them as a fighter.





CHAPTER 3

Fights

Every fight in Nightwake is a trade. You swing, and the Unmade answers. Roll well and it never touches you; roll badly and you pay for every blow you land.

The roll

Roll **five dice**. Every die showing **5 or 6 is a hit**.

You always roll against an enemy's **Guard**, a number from 1 to 3. There are no opposed rolls: the enemy never rolls to defend.

- **Hits equal to or more than its Guard:** a clean strike. The enemy can't touch you.
- **Fewer hits than its Guard:** the enemy **hits you back**. You lose Vigor equal to its **Harm**, then gain **1 Chi** (unless you went Down). Pain is fuel.

Either way, your **damage** is your number of hits, plus any bonuses. Bonuses count only if you rolled at least one hit. Damage comes off the enemy's **Toughness**; at 0 it falls.

A **Critical** is a roll that meets the Guard **and** shows two or more 6s. It deals **+1 damage** and gives you **1 Chi**.

A roll's result comes first. If your Strike destroys the enemy, it can't hit back.

BONUS DICE: NEVER MORE THAN +2

Your Chi die, Help and the Quick perk add dice to a roll. However many you are offered, you roll at most **two bonus dice**, so a roll is never more than seven dice. Roll your two bonus dice in a different colour and the cap takes care of itself.

EXAMPLE: A STRIKE

Jun strikes a Warden with Guard 2. He spends 1 Chi for a bonus die and rolls six dice: 6, 5, 3, 3, 2, 1. Two hits: he meets the Guard, so the Warden can't hit back. Damage is 2, +1 from his Brawler style for meeting the Guard: **3 damage**. Only one 6, so no Critical.

Had he rolled one hit, he would still deal 1 damage (no Brawler bonus, because he missed the Guard), and then lose 2 Vigor to the Warden's Harm and gain 1 Chi.

The round

A fight is a series of **rounds**. Each round has three steps:

1. **Fighters act**, one at a time, in any order the players like.
2. **Enemies act.** The Warden or the Heart feeds on its Stills. Then each pack Swarms, then the Warden or the Heart Surges (Chapter 6).
3. **End of round.** Awakenings count down, then the clocks are checked (Chapter 5).

Actions

When it is your turn, take **one action**:

- **Strike** an enemy: roll against its Guard, as above.
- **Rally** a Down fighter: they get up with **2 Vigor**. No roll. They act from the next round.

These are **free**, not actions:

- a **Chi die**: spend 1 Chi for a bonus die on your own roll;
- **Help**: spend 1 Chi to give another fighter's roll a bonus die. Each helper can Help a roll once. Down fighters can't Help;
- your element's **technique**, declared with a Strike (Chapter 2).

Outside fights there are no rolls. Climbing, running, talking a frightened bus driver into leaving: describe it and it happens. Nothing outside a fight costs Vigor, Chi or Hours unless these rules say so.

Feeding: walking the cycle

The fighters' elements form a ring in the feeding cycle's order: **Wood → Fire → Earth → Metal → Water → back to Wood**. Any element nobody has is **skipped**, so the ring always closes, however many of you there are.

A Strike deals **+1 damage** (if it hits) when the action just before it in this fight was taken by the fighter before you in the ring.

- Any action counts: a Strike, a Rally, holding a Seal, a Quick fighter's free Strike, and the last action of the round before.
- Two actions in a row by the same fighter don't feed.

EXAMPLE: A RING OF THREE

The fighters are Wood, Earth and Water. Fire and Metal are missing, so the ring is **Wood → Earth → Water → Wood**. If they act in that order every round, every Strike after the very first one in the fight is fed. If Water Rallies someone instead of striking, Wood is still fed next, because the Rally was Water's action.

Resolving a Strike, in order

1. Declare your technique and your bonus dice (your Chi die, then any Help).
2. Roll.
3. Reroll, if you can: Water's Tide first, then Lucky.
4. Count hits.
5. Deal damage, and Sweeper's extra damage.
6. Wood's Renewal heals.
7. If you missed the Guard and the enemy is still standing, it hits you back; Counter answers.
8. Gain Chi for a Critical.

Vigor and going Down

Vigor is how much punishment you can take. When you would lose Vigor, these protections apply in this order: a **Guardian** may take the loss for you; then **Bulwark**; then **Flow**; then **Unbreakable**.

At **0 Vigor** you are **Down**:

- you can't act or Help;
- you **lose all your Chi**;
- your Awakening, if you are Awakened, ends.

Harm past 0 is lost. Another fighter can **Rally** you. When the fight ends, every Down fighter stands up with **1 Vigor**. Nobody dies in Nightwake; but a fighter who is Down is no use to anyone, and a group that is all Down at the Heart has lost the night.

Vigor carries from fight to fight. Nothing heals you except a Respite, a Rally, and the powers that say so.

How a fight ends

- **The enemy falls.** When a Warden or the Heart falls, its Stills crumble and the fight is won. The First Clash is won when its last Still falls.
- **Every fighter is Down.** At an Anchor, the Anchor stands (Chapter 5). At the Heart, the night is lost.
- **The fighters withdraw** from an Anchor, at the end of any round.
- **The clock runs out.** Every fight ends at the end of round 7 (Chapter 5).

If the same Strike destroys the Heart and puts the last fighter Down, the fighters win.

EXAMPLE: ONE ROUND AT AN ANCHOR

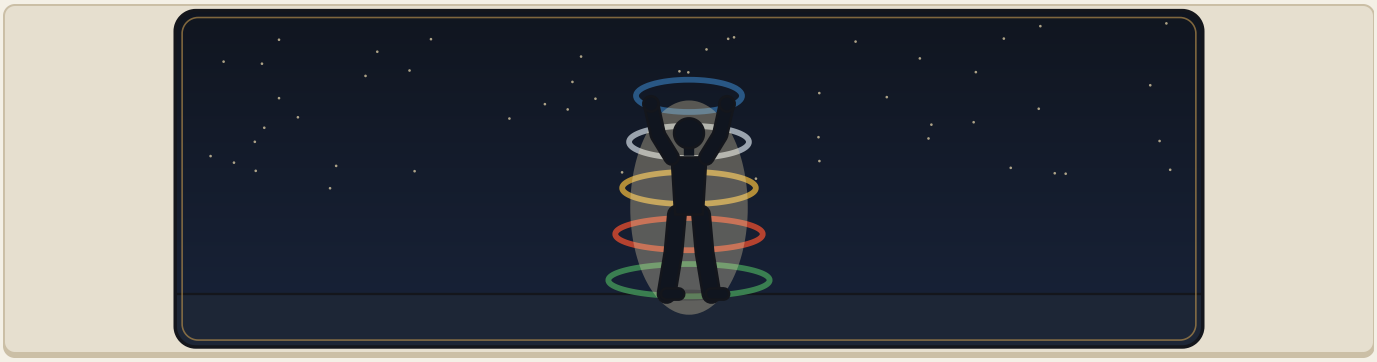
Ana (Wood, a Sweeper), Marcus (Fire) and Priya (Metal) face a Warden with an Earth Shell and a pack of three Stills. The ring is Wood → Fire → Metal → Wood.

Ana acts first. As the Wood fighter she breaks Earth Shells, so the Warden's Guard is 2 for her, not 3. She hits it twice: 2 damage, and her hit shatters the Shell. As a Sweeper who met the Guard, she also deals 1 damage to the pack.

Marcus is next in the ring, so he is fed: +1 damage if he hits. He spends 1 Chi on Blaze and strikes the Warden: one hit, short of its Guard of 2. Damage 1 + 2 (Blaze) + 1 (fed) = 4. The Warden hits back for 2 Harm, and Marcus gains 1 Chi.

Priya is fed by Marcus. She strikes the pack (Guard 1) with three hits: 3 damage + 1 fed = 4. The pack had 9 Toughness and took 1 from Ana, so it is down to 4: two Stills left.

Enemies act. The Warden regains 2 Toughness for the two Stills still standing. The pack Swarms for 1 Harm (half of 2): the players give it to Marcus. Then the Warden Surges.



CHAPTER 4

Chi and the Awakening

Chi is the element moving through you: the heat behind the punch, the stillness before the throw. You will never have much of it, and you should never keep it long.

Chi

You start the night with **2 Chi** and can hold at most **5**. Any Chi you would gain past 5 is lost.

GAINING CHI

- **1** each time an enemy hits you back (unless it puts you Down);
- **1** on a Critical;
- **3** for every fighter when the Heart fight begins;
- more from Breath, Guardian, Counter, Trained and Harmony.

SPENDING CHI

SPEND	CHI	EFFECT
Chi die	1	A bonus die on your own roll
Help	1	A bonus die on another fighter's roll
Technique	1	Your element's technique, with a Strike
Awaken	3	Your Awakening (below)

LOSING CHI

You lose **all your Chi** when you go Down, and some when the Unmade **Drains** it (Chapter 6). Chi left over at dawn is worth nothing.

> **DESIGNER'S NOTE: SPEND IT**
>
> In thousands of simulated nights, the groups that spent their Chi as they got it did better than the groups that saved it. You will get it back: every hit back refills you, and the Heart gives everyone the 3 Chi they need to Awaken. A fighter sitting on 5 Chi is wasting every point they gain.

The Awakening

Once a night, you can become what your element has been trying to make you.

> **AWAKENING**
>
> - **Once per night,** at the **start of your turn**, spend **3 Chi** to Awaken.
> - You may Awaken from the moment **the first fighter goes Down** tonight, or once **the Heart fight begins**, whichever comes first.
> - It lasts **3 rounds**, counting the round you Awaken (Seal lasts 2). It ends early if you go Down or the fight ends.

Your Awakening is the one you picked when you made your fighter. Describe it big: this is the moment the city will remember.

ASCENDANT

Each of your hits deals **2 damage**. Double your hits first, then add bonuses such as feeding or Blaze. Hits still count once against the Guard.

UNBREAKABLE

You **lose no Vigor**, from anything. Enemies still hit you back when you miss their Guard, so you still gain Chi.

WELLSPRING

At the **start of each round** while it lasts, share out **2 Vigor** among the fighters, as you choose. A Down fighter given any stands up and acts that round. Since you Awaken on your turn, the first share comes at the start of the next round.

TEMPEST

You take **two actions** each round, one after the other, and your Strikes **can't be hit back**. Your second action is never fed by your first.

SEAL

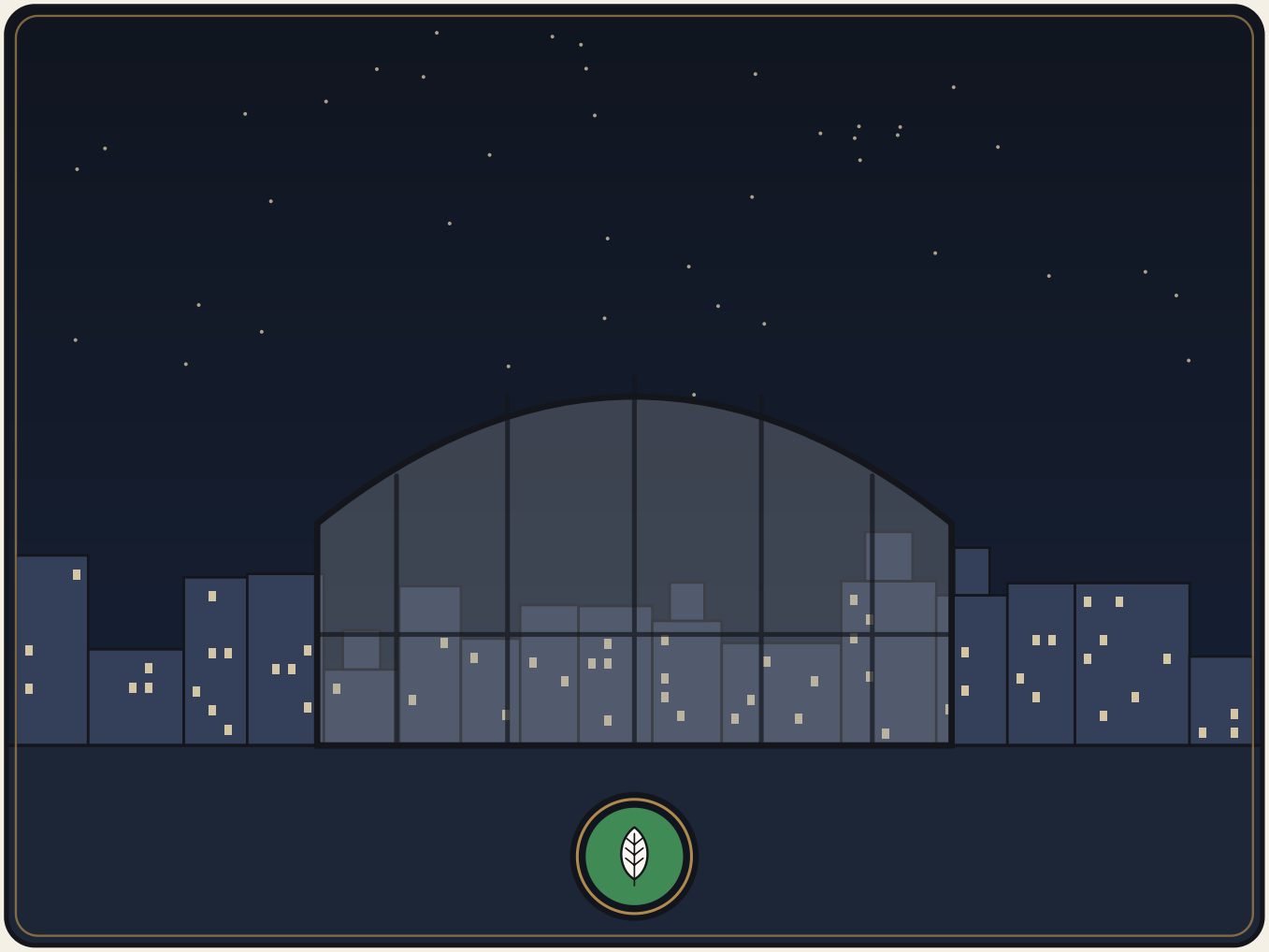
The Warden or the Heart **can't Surge**. Holding the Seal is your action each round, starting with the round you Awaken: you can't Strike or Rally, but you can still Help. Your held Seal counts as your action for feeding. It lasts **2 rounds**, and Stills still Swarm.

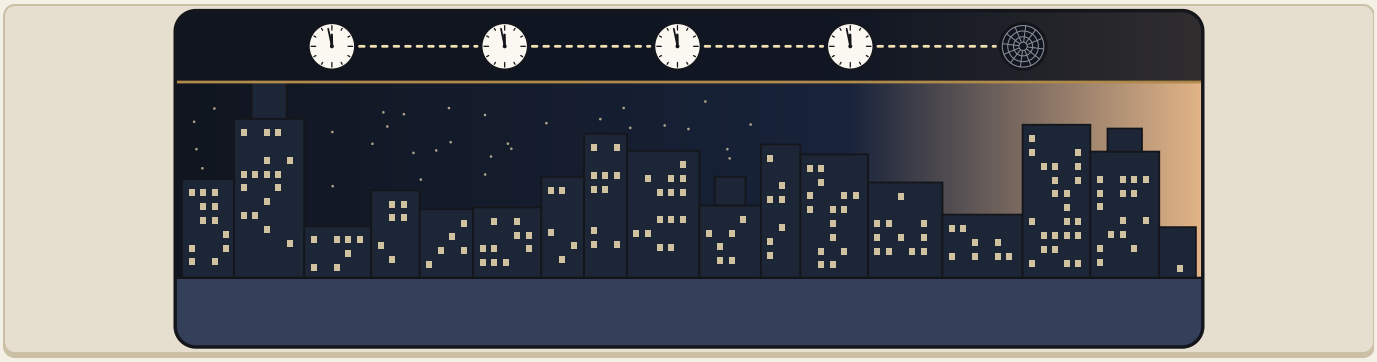
HARMONY

At the **start of each round** while it lasts, share out **3 Chi** among the fighters, as you choose (no one past 5). The first share comes at the start of the next round.

WHEN TO AWAKEN

Most nights, save your Awakening for the Heart: every fighter gets the 3 Chi to pay for it there, and the Heart is where it matters most. Awaken in the Hunt only when a fight is going badly: someone is Down and the Warden is still strong. Awakening at the first chance simply costs you the Heart.





CHAPTER 5

The Night

Midnight to dawn: six Hours. The Unmade only needs one of them to go wrong for you.

Every night of Nightwake has the same shape: a **Prologue**, the **Hunt** and the **Heart**, then an **Epilogue**. The Storyteller keeps the clocks on the Night sheet, where everyone can see them.

SCENE	AT THE TABLE
Setup: fighters and the Night card	20–30 minutes
Prologue and the First Clash	25 minutes
The Hunt: four Hours	about 25 minutes each
The Heart	35–40 minutes
Epilogue	10 minutes

The Prologue

Go round the table. Each player describes, in a few sentences, the moment their element woke: where they were, what happened, what they did next. The Storyteller asks one question of each (Chapter 7 has some).

Then the Unmade finds them. The **First Clash** is a fight against a pack of **2 Stills per fighter**, with no Warden. It throws the fighters together and teaches the rules. It costs no Hour, and it is won when the last Still falls.

The Hunt

The Unmade has taken hold of the city at five places, its **Anchors**. Each Anchor has a **Warden**, and each Warden wears a **Shell** of a different element (Chapter 6). The Storyteller tells the players all five Anchors and their Shells at the start of the Hunt.

The Hunt lasts **4 Hours**. At the start of each Hour, the group chooses one:

- **Strike an Anchor.** Fight its Warden and a pack of **1 Still per fighter**. If the Warden falls, the Anchor **breaks**.
- **Take a Respite.** Hide, breathe, patch each other up. Every fighter returns to **full Vigor** and every Down fighter stands. Chi is unchanged.

THE HUNT'S CLOCKS

- **Long fight:** an Anchor fight still going at the end of **round 4** costs **one more Hour**. If no Hours are left, dawn comes one round sooner at the Heart instead.
- **The Warden holds:** an Anchor fight still going at the end of **round 7** ends, and the Anchor stands.
- **Withdraw:** at the end of any round, the group can withdraw. The Anchor stands, and Down fighters stand up with 1 Vigor.
- **Everyone Down:** the Anchor stands, and everyone wakes with 1 Vigor.
- **The Hunt ends** when the Hours run out, or when every Anchor is broken.

Losing an Anchor fight still costs the Hour, and the Anchor stays standing to strengthen the Heart. Withdrawing keeps your Vigor; being beaten doesn't. Neither is ever better than winning.

The Heart

In the last Hour, wherever they are, the fighters are drawn to the Heart. They fight it and a pack of **1 Still per fighter**.

- **Every Anchor still standing** makes the Heart tougher (Chapter 6). Its Toughness is fixed as the fight begins.
- As the fight begins, **every fighter gains 3 Chi**, and anyone may Awaken.
- Nobody can withdraw from the Heart.

- **Dawn** breaks at the end of **round 7**, one round sooner for each Hour owed by a long fight.

Endings

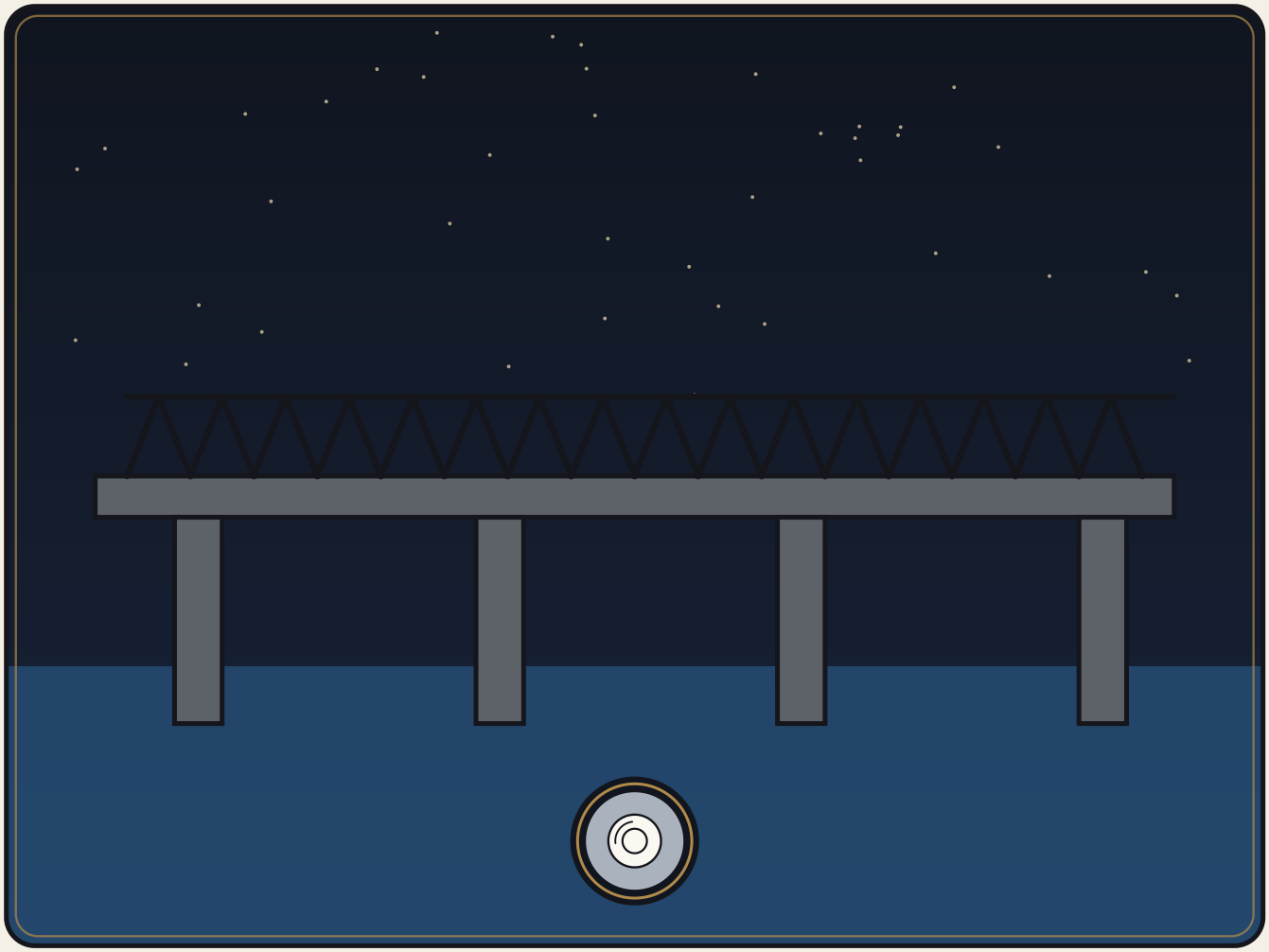
ENDING	WHEN	WHAT IT MEANS
Win	The Heart falls	The clocks start again. Whatever the Unmade took comes back with the sun.
Driven off	Dawn breaks with the Heart at half its Toughness or less	The Unmade retreats into the dark. The city is scarred, some of what it took stays taken, and it will come back.
Loss	Every fighter is Down at the Heart, or dawn breaks with the Heart above half	The Unmade takes hold. The sun rises on a city that has stopped.

The Epilogue

Go round once more. Each player says where their fighter is when the sun comes up, and one thing they will never tell anyone about tonight. Chapter 7 has an epilogue for each ending.

WHAT WINS NIGHTS

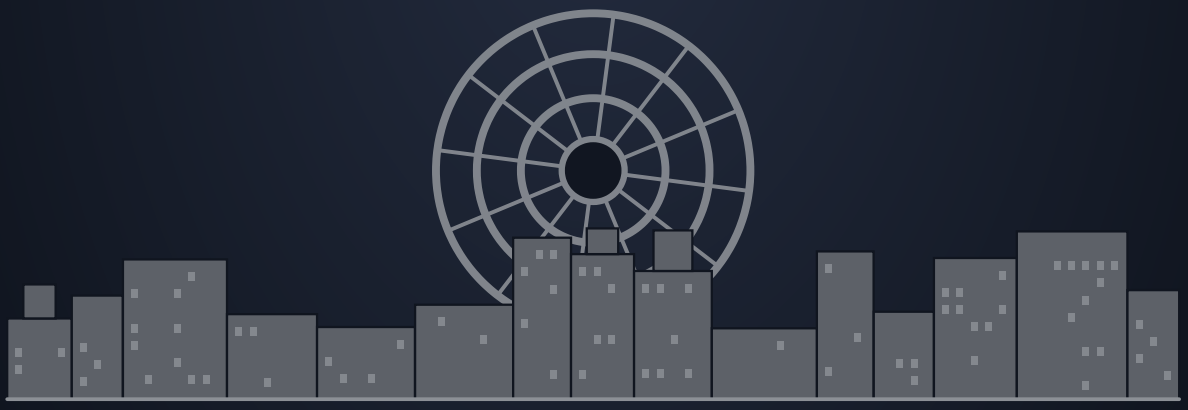
- **Walk the ring.** Act in cycle order and nearly every Strike is fed.
- **Thin the Stills, but don't chase the last one.** Every standing Still heals the Warden or Heart, and Stills crumble when their master falls.
- **Rest at about two-thirds.** Take a Respite when the group is down to about two-thirds of its Vigor. Resting much later loses nights; resting much earlier leaves too many Anchors standing.
- **Break the Anchors you can break.** Pick the Anchors whose Shells your elements break.
- **Spend Chi, save the Awakening.** See Chapter 4.

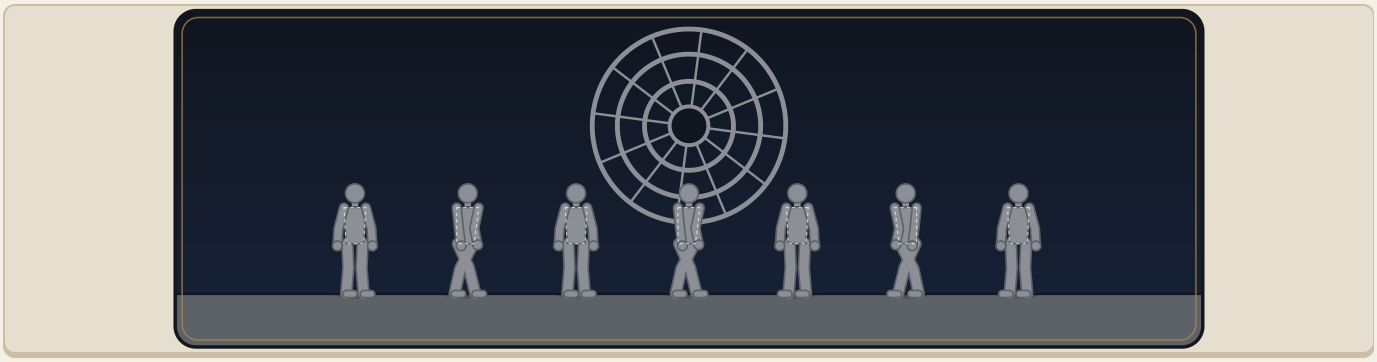


PART TWO

The Unmade

For the Storyteller: the enemy and its numbers, how to run a night, a ready-made night in an ordinary city, and tables for making nights of your own.





CHAPTER 6

The Unmade

The five phases never stop: Wood feeds Fire, Fire becomes Earth, and round again, forever. The Unmade is what lies outside that turning: no element, no change, nothing becoming anything else. It does not destroy. It stops.

Every few lifetimes the Unmade presses against a city. It cannot hold the world on its own, so it hollows out places and things and wears them: its **Anchors**. Where it touches, the world goes grey and quiet. Its servants are copies peeled from the city: shadows, reflections, outlines. When it is driven out, what it took comes back.

Stills

Stills are the Unmade's rank and file: shapes peeled from the city and set walking. A crowd's shadows. A bus driver's reflection, still holding the wheel. The outline of a statue. They are grey, silent, and move in jerks, like a film with frames missing. When one falls it breaks into dust that hangs in the air and does not settle.

A pack of Stills

GUARD 1 HARM 1 TOUGHNESS 3 per Still

One target: A pack is fought as one enemy. Damage carries over from one Still to the next; a pack with 4 Toughness left has two Stills standing.

Swarm: At the end of each round, the pack deals Harm equal to **half its Stills** (rounded up), as one blow, to one fighter of the players' choice.

Crumble: When their Warden or the Heart falls, its Stills crumble.

Wardens and their Shells

Each Anchor has a **Warden**: the thing the Unmade hollowed out to hold that place, made huge and grey. It wears a **Shell** of whatever it was made from: the iron of a bridge, the roots of an old tree, the water of a reservoir.

Warden

GUARD 2 (+1 Shell) **HARM** 2 **TOUGHNESS** 9 per fighter **CRUSH** 3 **SWEEP** 1

Shell: +1 Guard (Guard 3) until it shatters. The element that **breaks** the Shell ignores it, and that element's first hit shatters it. It also shatters once the Warden is at **half its Toughness** or less.

Feeds on its Stills: At the end of each round, before anything else acts, it regains **1 Toughness for each of its Stills** still standing, never above its starting Toughness.

Surge: At the end of each round, after the Swarm, roll on the Surge table.

SHELL	BROKEN BY	THE WARDEN MIGHT BE MADE OF…
Wood	Metal	old trees, a park, timber, paper
Fire	Water	a furnace, neon, a power station
Earth	Wood	stone, brick, a tunnel, a quarry
Metal	Fire	a bridge, rails, cars, a bell
Water	Earth	a reservoir, the river, rain, ice

The Heart

The **Heart** is where the Unmade gathers itself: a hole in the city's motion. Around it clocks stop, smoke hangs in the air like glass, and sound arrives late or not at all. It has no element, so no Shell; but every Anchor still standing feeds it.

The Heart

GUARD 2 **HARM** 2 **TOUGHNESS** see the Night card **CRUSH / SWEEP** see the Night card

Toughness: (5 + 4 for each Anchor still standing) × the number of fighters. With five fighters, use 6 instead of 5. Fixed as the fight begins.

Feeds on its Stills: As a Warden.

Surge: As a Warden, using the Heart's column.

The Surge table

At the end of each round, after any Swarm, the Warden or the Heart rolls one die:

D6	SURGE	WARDEN	HEART
1–2	**Crush**	3 Harm to the fighter who dealt it the most damage this round	the Night card's Crush, to the same fighter
3–4	**Sweep**	every fighter loses 1 Vigor	every fighter loses the Night card's Sweep
5	**Drain**	the fighter with the most Chi loses 2 Chi	every fighter loses 1 Chi
6	**Call**	2 more Stills join its pack (or form a new one), up to fighters + 2 Stills	the same

- **Crush when nobody damaged it this round:** it hits the fighter with the most Vigor.
- **Ties**, for a Crush or a Drain: the fighter among them who acted last that round.
- **A Drain that finds no Chi** Crushes instead.
- **New Stills** from a Call don't Swarm until the next round.
- **A Sealed** Warden or Heart doesn't Surge, but still feeds on its Stills, and its Stills still Swarm.

The Night card

Pick a difficulty before the night begins. Use Easy for a first night or a young table, Standard for most nights, Hard for a group that wants to lose sometimes. Only the Heart changes:

THE HEART'S	EASY	STANDARD	HARD
Crush	2	4	6
Sweep	1	2	3

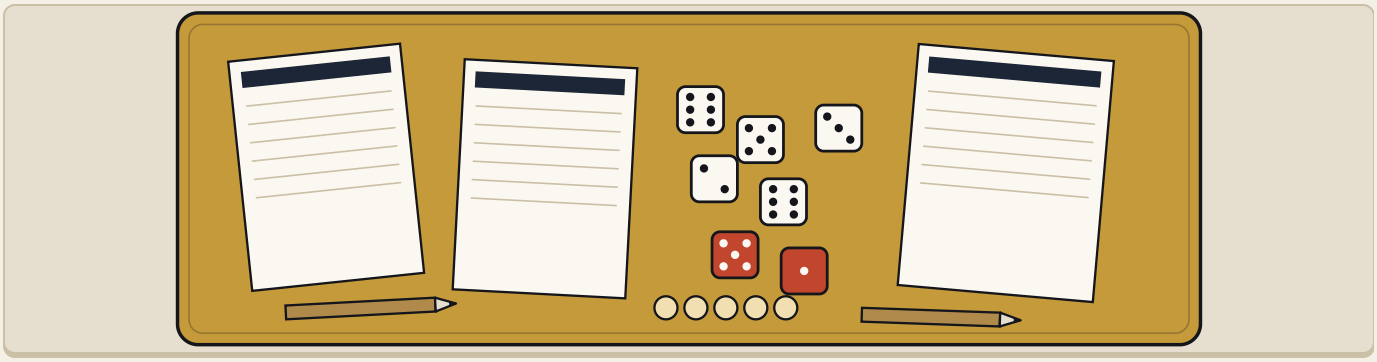
The size of everything else depends on the number of fighters:

FIGHTERS	3	4	5
Starting Vigor	10	7	6
Warden Toughness	27	36	45
Heart Toughness, every Anchor broken	15	20	30
…plus, per Anchor standing	+12	+16	+20
Stills: First Clash	6	8	10
Stills: an Anchor, the Heart	3	4	5
A Call fills a pack up to	5	6	7

DESIGNER'S NOTE: WHAT THE LABELS MEAN

The labels come from simulated nights played strictly by these rules, with sensible habits and random groups of fighters. Out of every hundred nights, groups win about **89** on Easy, **75** on Standard and **61** on Hard, and lose outright about **1**, **10** and **21**; the rest end with the Unmade driven off at dawn. Three, four and five fighters do equally well. A group that ignores the Stills wins only about half its Standard nights.





CHAPTER 7

Running the Night

You are the city and everything in it: the bus driver who won't leave without his passengers, the hum of a substation going quiet, and the Unmade itself. You are also the clock. Be generous with the first, and never with the second.

Your job

- **Describe** the city and the Unmade, and let the players describe their own fighters, blows and powers.
- **Run the enemies.** They don't make choices; they follow the Surge table and the targeting rules in Chapter 6. Roll in the open.
- **Keep the clocks** on the Night sheet, where everyone can see them: Hours left, Anchors standing, Hours owed, and the round.
- **Ask questions.** "What does your Fire sound like?" is worth more than a paragraph of description.
- **Keep it moving.** An Hour of the Hunt should take about 25 minutes of play.

THE ROUND, FROM YOUR SIDE

1. **Fighters act** in the order the players choose. Track damage on the Night sheet.
2. **Enemies act:** the Warden or Heart regains 1 Toughness per standing Still; each pack Swarms (the players choose who takes it); the Warden or Heart rolls its Surge.
3. **End of round:** Awakenings count down. Round 4 at an Anchor: has it become a long fight? Round 7: the fight ends.

Before the night

FIRST NIGHT IN UNDER 30 MINUTES

- Print the fighter sheets, the Night sheet and the At the Table card.
- Hand out the five ready-made fighters (Chapter 2); players with fewer seats pick any of them. Settle clashes with a die roll.
- Read out the elements and the two cycles (Chapter 1), then the round (Chapter 3). Leave the rest until it comes up.
- Pick the difficulty: **Easy** for a first night.
- Fill in the Night sheet from the Night card: Warden and Heart Toughness for this many fighters, the five Anchors and their Shells.
- Agree on lines and pauses (Chapter 1).

The Prologue

Ask each player one of these, or your own:

- What were you doing at two minutes to midnight?
- What was the first thing your element did, before you knew it was yours?
- Who is the one person in this city you need to still be here tomorrow?
- What did you see the Stills take?

Then bring them together. The First Clash should feel like an ambush: the Stills come out of the walls, the fighters meet each other mid-fight. Teach the rules as they come up and let the first Critical land big.

The Hunt

Tell the players all five Anchors, their places and their Shells, and let them choose where to go. Choosing is half the Hunt: which Shells can we break, and can we afford to rest?

Between Anchors, give each fighter one moment: a sentence of the empty city, a question, a glimpse of what the Unmade has taken. Travel costs nothing. Don't let it take longer than five minutes.

At each Anchor, describe the Warden before the first round: what it was, what it has become, and what its Shell looks like. Then fight.

The Heart

Count the Anchors still standing and say what each one adds: the Heart remembers the bridge, the reservoir, the old greenhouse. Give every fighter their 3 Chi and invite them to Awaken. Count the rounds aloud as dawn comes up: "That's round five. The sky's going grey."

Epilogues

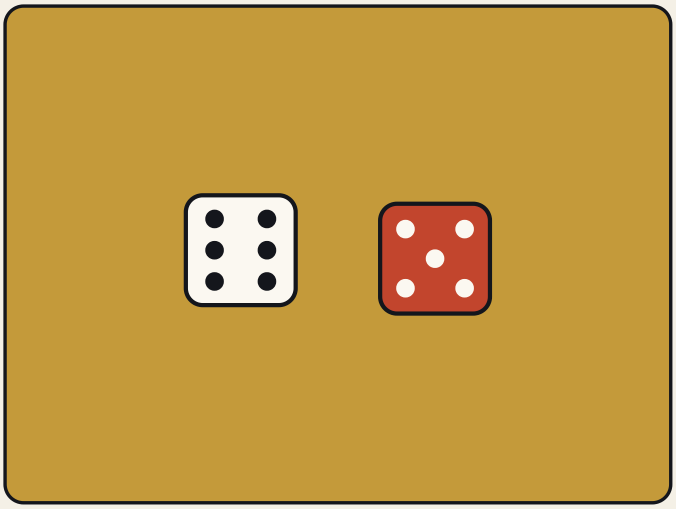
- **Win:** the clocks start, all at once, a second late. Ask each player where their fighter watches the sunrise, and who they call first.
- **Driven off:** the Unmade pulls back into the dark, taking something with it: a street that no one remembers, a statue that is now only a plinth. Ask each player what they lost, and what they will do when it comes back.
- **Loss:** dawn comes, and nothing moves. Ask each player for one last thing their fighter does while their element still burns. Then describe the city waiting, perfectly still, for someone else to wake.

Running fights well

- **Let the players describe their hits;** you describe the Unmade's.
- **Say the targets.** When you roll a Crush, name who it is coming for before you apply it.
- **Make the Stills matter.** Every round, remind the table how much Toughness the Stills just gave back to their master.
- **Telegraph the clocks.** "End of round four. If this Warden is still up, it's costing you an Hour."
- **Don't soften rolls.** The numbers were tested; the night is as hard as the label says.

Respecting the five phases

The Wu Xing is a real tradition, centuries old, still part of medicine, architecture and daily life for millions of people. Describe the elements by what they do: growth, heat, steadiness, edges, flow. Don't invent pseudo-Chinese words or writing, don't give anyone an accent, and don't tie an element to any kind of person. Any element can wake in anyone.





CHAPTER 8

The Night the Clocks Stopped

A ready-made night for any city: five Anchors, a Heart and everything you need to run it tonight.

Set it in your own city, or in no city in particular. Everything here exists somewhere in every city big enough to have a night bus.

Midnight

At two minutes to midnight, every clock in the city stops. Phones freeze on 23:58. The trains stop between stations. Most people don't notice: they stop too, mid-step, mid-word, standing still where they were, as if waiting for something. Only five people keep moving.

Run the Prologue (Chapter 7). Then begin the First Clash.

The First Clash: the night bus station

The fighters are drawn, one by one, to the bus station: the last place in the city with its lights on. A night bus stands at the stop, its passengers frozen in their seats. Their reflections are getting off.

Enemies: a pack of 2 Stills per fighter, no Warden · **Won when** the last Still falls · **Costs** no Hour

When the last reflection breaks, the station clock's hands twitch. From the roof the fighters can see five places where the city has gone grey. The Hunt begins.

The five Anchors

Read the players all five. The order is theirs.

The Old Greenhouse



Shell: Wood · **Broken by:** Metal

The Victorian glasshouse in the park. Every plant inside has turned the colour of ash and stopped growing mid-curl. The Warden is **the Gardener**: a hunched giant of grey roots and ironwork, the glasshouse's frame grown into its back.

On arrival: the glass panes hang loose in the air above the roof, like a held breath.

The Substation



Shell: Fire · **Broken by:** Water

The power station by the canal, humming without making a sound. The Warden is **the Stoker**: a figure of cold grey flame, its fire frozen into the shape of fire, shedding sparks that hang where they fall.

On arrival: every street light for a mile is lit but gives no light.

The Underpass



Shell: Earth · **Broken by:** Wood

The pedestrian tunnel under the ring road, tiled and echoing. The Warden is **the Mason**: brickwork and paving slabs stacked into the shape of a person, too wide for the tunnel, its footsteps leaving no echo.

On arrival: the graffiti has drained off the walls and lies in a grey puddle on the floor.

The Iron Bridge



Shell: Metal · **Broken by:** Fire

The old railway bridge over the river, with a freight train stopped halfway across. The Warden is **the Girder**: a towering frame of riveted iron and coupling chains, the train's headlamp burning grey in its chest.

On arrival: the rails ring like a struck bell, once, and keep ringing in your teeth.

The Reservoir



Shell: Water · **Broken by:** Earth

The great old reservoir behind the waterworks. Its surface stands up off the ground in a sheet. The Warden is **the Overflow**: a wave that never broke, grey and glassy, with the shapes of things it swallowed turning slowly inside it.

On arrival: the rain stopped falling an hour ago; the drops are still up there.

Every Anchor: its Warden and a pack of 1 Still per fighter · Warden numbers in Chapter 6

The Heart: the clock tower

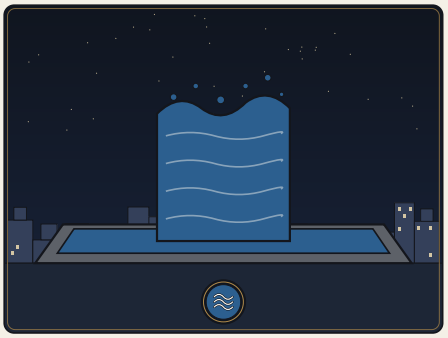
In the last Hour, every stopped clock in the city points the same way: to the old clock tower in the square. The square is full of frozen people, all looking up. Above them the clock face has gone dark, and in the dark something turns very slowly, like a great wheel with nothing on it. That is the Heart.

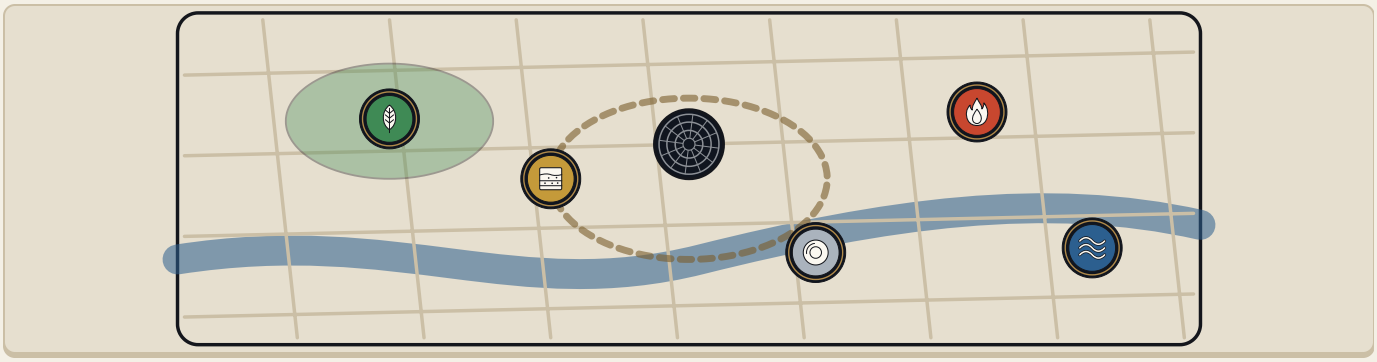
For each Anchor still standing, show its piece in the Heart: roots through the clock's works, cold fire behind its face, brick, iron, a hanging sheet of water.

Enemies: the Heart and a pack of 1 Still per fighter · Toughness and Surges from the Night card · **Dawn** at the end of round 7, sooner for each Hour owed

Morning

Use the epilogues in Chapter 7. If the Heart falls, the clock tower strikes midnight six hours late, and the city starts moving again, mid-step, mid-word, as if nothing happened. Only five people know otherwise.





CHAPTER 9

Making Your Own Night

EVERY CITY HAS A PLACE WHERE THE WATER IS HELD back, a place where the iron is old, and a place where the trees remember what was there before the streets. That is where the Unmade will take hold.

Building a night

1. **Pick or roll the First Clash** on its table.
2. **Make five Anchors, one for each Shell.** For each element, pick or roll a place on that element's table. Each entry names its Warden.
3. **Pick or roll a sign of the Unmade** for each Anchor: what the fighters see when they arrive.
4. **Pick or roll the Heart.**

ALWAYS FIVE SHELLS

Every night has exactly **five Anchors, one for each Shell element**, so every fighter's element has a Shell to break and no group is left without one. Every result on these tables can be used in any night. If you roll a place your city doesn't have, take the nearest thing it does.

The numbers never change: every Warden is a Warden (Chapter 6), whatever it is made of. What you are choosing is the city, the picture and the story.

The First Clash

D6	WHERE THE FIGHTERS MEET
1	The night bus station: the passengers' reflections are getting off.
2	An all-night launderette: the shadows in the drums are climbing out.
3	A 24-hour supermarket: the security monitors show grey shoppers who aren't there.
4	An all-night diner: every customer's outline stands up and leaves its body behind.
5	A nightclub queue: the music stops; the queue's shadows keep dancing towards you.
6	The last train home, stopped between stations: something is walking down the carriages.

Wood Shells • broken by Metal

D6	PLACE	WARDEN
1	The old greenhouse in the park	the Gardener, roots and glasshouse ironwork
2	The central library	the Archivist, grey books stacked into a body
3	A timber yard by the river	the Sawyer, planks and sawdust in a coat of bark
4	The oldest tree in the city	the Elder, the tree itself, walking
5	The cemetery's yew avenue	the Keeper, a hedge cut into the shape of a man
6	An old wooden pier	the Piling, barnacled posts and rope

Fire Shells • broken by Water

D6	PLACE	WARDEN
1	The substation by the canal	the Stoker, frozen grey flame
2	The night market's grills	the Cook, smoke and skewers and still coals
3	A glassworks	the Glassblower, half-melted, half-cold
4	The neon street of the theatre district	the Marquee, a tangle of dead neon letters
5	The old gasworks	the Holder, a gasometer's iron frame wrapped in grey fire
6	A bonfire on the waste ground	the Guy, a straw figure burning without heat

Earth Shells • broken by Wood

D6	PLACE	WARDEN
1	The underpass under the ring road	the Mason, brick and paving slabs
2	The cathedral crypt	the Effigy, a stone knight risen from its tomb
3	The brickworks	the Kiln, a chimney on stone legs
4	The multi-storey car park	the Ramp, concrete levels folded into a giant
5	The old city wall	the Rampart, the wall's gatehouse, standing up
6	The deepest underground station	the Tunneller, clay and tiles and grey roots of cable

Metal Shells • broken by Fire

D6	PLACE	WARDEN
1	The iron railway bridge	the Girder, rivets and coupling chains
2	The scrapyard	the Crusher, cars folded into a fist
3	The railway sidings	the Points, rails bent into long legs
4	The church bell tower	the Tolling, a bell that rings without sound
5	The bank vault	the Strongroom, a door that walks
6	The shopping centre's escalators	the Stair, steel steps coiled like a spine

Water Shells • broken by Earth

D6	PLACE	WARDEN
1	The reservoir behind the waterworks	the Overflow, a wave that never broke
2	The harbour	the Anchorage, a ship's hull of grey water
3	The public baths	the Lifeguard, the pool stood up on its end
4	The canal lock	the Lock-Keeper, held-back water in a gate's shape
5	The weir on the river	the Undertow, a waterfall frozen mid-fall
6	The ice rink	the Skater, ice carved by nobody

Signs of the Unmade

D6	ON ARRIVAL, THE FIGHTERS SEE…
1	Rain hanging in the air, drop by drop.
2	Every clock, phone and screen showing 23:58.
3	Shadows walking away from the people who cast them.
4	Sound arriving late: you see the glass break, and hear it a breath later.
5	Colour draining out of everything, street by street.
6	A crowd frozen mid-step, every face turned towards the Anchor.

The Heart

D6	WHERE THE HEART TURNS
1	Behind the face of the old clock tower.
2	Under the glass roof of the central station.
3	Over the centre spot of the empty stadium.
4	At the top of the tallest building, above the city lights.
5	In the fountain of the main square, where the water stands still.
6	In the dome of the old observatory, where the stars have stopped.

Fighter

One per player. Pencil: Vigor and Chi change all night.

Name _____ **Before tonight** _____

When it woke _____

ELEMENT AND TECHNIQUE (1 CHI, WITH A STRIKE)	FEEDS · BREAKS

FIGHTING STYLE	PERK

AWAKENING (3 CHI, START OF YOUR TURN, 3 ROUNDS)	AWAKENED TONIGHT
	☐

Vigor Start: 10 / 7 / 6 for 3 / 4 / 5 fighters, +3 if Tough. Cross off the boxes you don't have.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Chi Start with 2. Never more than 5. All lost when you go Down.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

This fight Clear at the end of every fight.

Lucky used ☐ Stubborn used ☐ Down ☐

NOTES: WHAT YOU SAW TONIGHT, WHO YOU NEED TO FIND

Roll 5 dice; 5 or 6 is a hit; at most 2 bonus dice. Meet the Guard or be hit back (lose its Harm, gain 1 Chi).

The Night

For the Storyteller. Keep it where everyone can see the clocks.

Fighters _____ **Difficulty** Easy ☐ Standard ☐ Hard ☐

Hours of the Hunt Cross one off for each Anchor fight, Respite and long fight.

○ ○ ○ ○ Hours owed (each brings dawn one round sooner): ☐ ☐ ☐

SHELL	BROKEN BY	ANCHOR AND WARDEN	BROKEN
Wood	Metal		☐
Fire	Water		☐
Earth	Wood		☐
Metal	Fire		☐
Water	Earth		☐

WARDEN TOUGHNESS (9 × FIGHTERS)	HEART TOUGHNESS: (5, OR 6 WITH FIVE FIGHTERS, + 4 × ANCHORS STANDING) × FIGHTERS

Round Anchor: a long fight after round 4 costs an Hour; the Warden holds after round 7. Heart: dawn after round 7, minus Hours owed.

1 2 3 **4** 5 6 **7**

WARDEN OR HEART: TOUGHNESS LEFT	PACK: TOUGHNESS LEFT (3 PER STILL)

D6	SURGE (END OF ROUND, AFTER THE SWARM)	WARDEN	HEART
1–2	Crush: most damage this round (else most Vigor)	3	Easy 2 · Std 4 · Hard 6
3–4	Sweep: every fighter	1	Easy 1 · Std 2 · Hard 3
5	Drain (no Chi: Crush)	most Chi loses 2	everyone loses 1
6	Call: +2 Stills, up to fighters + 2	the same	

Before the Swarm: the Warden or Heart regains 1 Toughness per standing Still. Swarm: half the Stills (round up), one blow, players choose who.

At the Table

Everything you need during play. The chapters have the details.

THE ROLL

Roll **5 dice**; each **5 or 6 is a hit**. At most **+2 bonus dice**. Damage = hits + bonuses (only with at least one hit). **Hits ≥ Guard:** clean. **Fewer:** hit back: lose its Harm, gain 1 Chi. **Critical:** Guard met and two 6s: +1 damage, +1 Chi. A Strike that destroys the enemy can't be hit back.

A ROUND

1. Fighters act, any order. 2. Enemies: the Warden or Heart regains 1 per standing Still; packs Swarm; the Warden or Heart Surges. 3. Awakenings count down; check the clocks.

ON YOUR TURN

One action: Strike, or Rally a Down fighter (up with 2 Vigor, acts next round). **Free:** Chi die (1 Chi, +1 die), Help (1 Chi, +1 die to another's roll, once per roll), your technique (1 Chi, with a Strike).

FEEDING

Ring: Wood → Fire → Earth → Metal → Water → Wood, skipping missing elements. If the action just before yours in this fight was by the fighter before you in the ring: +1 damage (if you hit).

A STRIKE, IN ORDER

Declare technique and bonus dice; roll; reroll (Tide, then Lucky); count hits; damage (and Sweeper); Renewal; hit back (and Counter); Critical Chi.

LOSING VIGOR

Guardian may take it; then Bulwark; then Flow; then Unbreakable. At 0: **Down**: no actions or Help, lose all Chi, Awakening ends. After the fight: stand with 1 Vigor.

TECHNIQUES (1 CHI)

Wood: after the roll, you or an ally +1 Vigor. **Fire:** +2 damage if you hit. **Earth:** a fighter's next loss this round is 3 less. **Metal:** each 6 is three hits. **Water:** reroll up to three misses.

CHI

Start 2, max 5. **Gain:** 1 when hit back; 1 on a Critical; 3 for everyone when the Heart fight begins. **Spend:** Chi die, Help, technique (1); Awaken (3).

AWAKENING

Once a night, start of your turn, 3 Chi. Open once someone has gone Down tonight, or at the Heart. Lasts 3 rounds counting this one (Seal 2); ends if you go Down or the fight ends.

THE NIGHT

First Clash: 2 Stills per fighter, no Hour. **Hunt, 4 Hours:** each Hour, an Anchor (Warden +1 Still per fighter) or a Respite (full Vigor, Down fighters stand). Long fight (past round 4): +1 Hour, or dawn 1 round sooner. Anchor fights end after round 7. Withdraw at the end of any round. **Heart:** +3 Chi each, no withdrawing, dawn after round 7.

ENDINGS

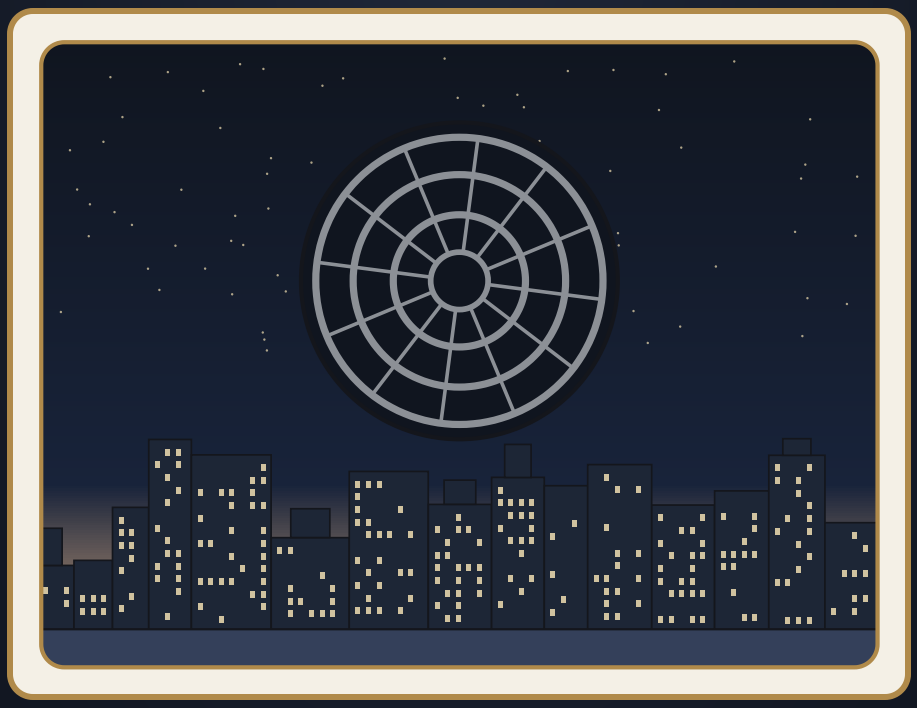
Win: the Heart falls. **Driven off:** dawn with the Heart at half or less. **Loss:** everyone Down at the Heart, or dawn with the Heart above half.

At two minutes to midnight, every clock in the city stopped.

Five ordinary people kept moving. A courier, a caretaker, a baker, a paramedic, a retired coach: each one awake to an element. Wood, Fire, Earth, Metal, Water.

Something from outside the world has taken hold of the city. It has hollowed out five places and gathered itself into a Heart, and if it is still holding on at sunrise, it will never let go.

Nightwake is a one-night roleplaying game for 3–5 players and a Storyteller. Make a fighter in five minutes, walk the cycle of the five elements, break the Anchors, and tear out the Heart before dawn.



Five elements. One night. Break the Heart before dawn.

NIGHTWAKE · VERSION 0.1